A GLASS NEARLY FULL

SIX MONTHS ON, THE CONGRESS REGIME HAS ROLLED OUT FOUR OF THE FIVE PRE-POLL 'GUARANTEES', BUT A FEW HICCUPS REMAIN

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PTI

At a time when the *revdi* versus welfare debate was raging, the Congress decided to rechristen its welfarist promises and call them 'guarantees'. The Grand Old Party went on to win the election in Karnataka on that steam. Six months down the line, the question everyone's asking is: how are they faring? For, on their perceived success or otherwise depends the Congress's appeal in the four big states going to elections this winter—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and neighbouring Telangana.

The Siddaramaiah-led Congress government's flagship scheme, the Anna Bhagya, ran into rough weather soon after it was announced in June (see *Blanket Coverage?*). Promising an additional five kilograms of rice to the central allocation of 5 kg to every ration card-holder, the scheme seemed destined for stillbirth when the Centre stopped the Food Corporation of India's (FCI) direct sales to states citing a possible shortfall in foodgrains production owing to predictions of an erratic monsoon. The state got itself out of that situation by deciding to wire the cash equivalent of 5 kg of rice directly to the bank accounts of beneficiaries. In the four months since July, the Karnataka government has transferred Rs 2,444 crore to over 11 million families, or 43 million individuals. In a review in October, the state cabinet decided to stick to the DBT (direct benefit transfer) format for the time being.

What drove that decision, officials say, was not so much the Rs 150-200 crore the state would save on transportation costs to supply the additional grain, which would add up to a monthly requirement of 228,000 tonnes. It was rather the sheer complexities involved—including the scope for irregularities—in ad hoc rice procurement arrangements from sundry agencies, none of which have the logistical heft of the FCI.

However, if the savings on this front were incidental, the other guarantees the state government has rolled out since it was voted into office in May could run up more than the budgeted expenditure—primarily because enrolment has been swift. These include the Gruha Lakshmi Yojana, under which each woman head of the family gets a monthly allowance of Rs 2,000; Gruha Jyothi, which promises free power to households